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Virginia Board of Education, Lab Schools Standing Committee, Monday, February 5, 2024

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[00:00:00] 3708.3 of the Code of Virginia and the all-virtual meeting policy adopted by the Board of Education on December 12, 2023. Dr. Armstrong, would you call the role of the Standing Committee members? Yes, ma'am.

[00:00:16] Ms. Wadiska? Present. Dr. Moran? Present. Mr. Hansen? Present.

[00:00:31] Mr. Bailey? And Mr. Rotherham? Thank you. our two other committee members join us virtually that will include them as the time that they added this meeting for the digital record at this time i'd like to ask a committee member to approve the amended the amended agenda was sent in advance of this meeting is there a motion to approve the amended agenda second all those in favor please signify by saying aye aye chair votes aye as well

[00:01:06] and the amended agenda is approved. We'll now move to the approval of the minutes. Is there a motion to approve the minutes as presented to the standing committee? So moved. Is there a second? Dr. Moran, is there a second? Yes, second. Thank you. All those in favor, please signify by saying aye. Aye.

[00:01:33] The share votes aye as well. Any opposed the same? The motion is approved and therefore the minutes are approved from the last meeting at this time normally in our committee meetings we take public comment on agenda items at this time we have no public comments from the public on any public

matters on our agenda however i'm just going to double check if there's any members of the public that would like to comment on items before the committee today this would be the time to do so so let me just pause and double check if there is any member of the public that would like to

[00:02:10] address the committee okay hearing none we'll continue to proceed with our agenda the first item for action today is item a which is first review of a college partnership lab school application from the university of virginia the committee will be hearing from dean stephanie roley school of education and human development at the university of virginia dr kim wilkins from the University of Virginia, and Dr. Gurley, superintendent of Charlottesville City Schools, followed by Dr. Armstrong. Dr. Armstrong will continue after we have an opportunity to hear

[00:02:49] from UVA. We'll do Q&A with the lab committee members, and then Dr. Armstrong will give us an update on the subject matter review of the application from UVA. So at this time, we'll turn it over to UVA to make a brief presentation to the lab committee members on their application to start a lab school here in the commonwealth of virginia dr roley are you going to be the one kicking it off for your institution thank you i am thank you um so just want to thank the standing

[00:03:23] committee for having us today and looking forward to the discussion about our lab school uh so can we go we can actually skip forward two slides i think tanya so um so why a lab school so uh so So I've been at UVA for a year and a half and reached out to Dr. Gurley pretty much immediately after I arrived in Charlottesville to just find out what we could do to partner as UVA and the Charlottesville city schools to make sure that all of our children in our community were prepared for the world.

[00:04:02] And in that conversation, he said that really workforce readiness was the thing that was on his mind and that we really wanted to think about some strategies that started in middle school. And so that conversation was really the seed of this lab school proposal.

[00:04:19] So I then took that back to our incredible team. We got together with the leadership from the schools and put together our initial proposal. So one of the things that we identified early on was the need for greater computational skill among middle school students going forward to make sure that they're ready for work when they graduated.

[00:04:44] But we didn't want to just provide computational skills in the usual way. We really wanted to do it in a way that was authentic, that reflected their communities, that reflected their lived experiences, that was led by them. And then most importantly, I think as well, that really reached across the curriculum.

[00:05:02] And so we'll talk more about the details there. But I think we have put together a great and exciting project that does those things. Of course, one of our big goals was to strengthen partnerships. And obviously, part of this is our partnership with the schools.

[00:05:20] but we also have partnerships with local community organizations that are focused on technical skills. And then within UVA, we're partnering with the Equity Center, with other schools and colleges around the university. We are also really focused on dissemination and thinking about how we can identify some best practices in this sort of work and then share with the community through a variety of different dissemination processes but we want to really create new knowledge around how to support children and how to support the teachers

[00:05:57] in providing this sort of environment and then finally this is part of a broader aim for us around these um these pipelines uh pipeline programs in k-12 education again focused on workforce

readiness and so this really fits with the mission of the school so we're excited and And I will pass it over to Dr. Gurley.

[00:06:22] - Good morning, good morning. So we know that it's very important for our middle schoolers to participate in experimental and hands-on learning. And our students engage in interdisciplinary projects, combining computer science with other academic areas, fostering learning beyond traditional classroom, beyond the classroom boundaries.

[00:06:48] and so we know the importance of STEM and computer science. We know that this approach prepares them for the real life challenges and sets a strong foundation for future academic and career success.

[00:07:07] Further, we know that true to our lab school ethos, we wanna create a community of practice for educators through rich professional development collaboration with UVA and local partners, we will bring innovative teaching methods and community resources into the classroom. This collaboration fosters educator growth, it leads to new pedagogical approaches, and it enriches our students' learning with diverse perspectives and enhanced opportunities. And lastly, we are centered on outcomes and student performance.

[00:07:47] and so aligned with the principles of the lab school our curriculum is rooted in cutting-edge research tailored to the development need developmental needs of our early middle mid-age adolescents and so we are focused on enhancing academic outcomes supporting social emotional growth and particularly in uplifting our underserved communities next slide we will have dr wilkes talk about um what our lab school vision is right thank you so much and i want to

[00:08:25] also acknowledge that we have several members of our planning uh lab school planning committee here so even though i'm going to be talking they're here supporting and also we'll be able to address questions we have dr chu associate professor at the uva school of education dr allen executive director of the uva equity center dr coffee coordinator of science and innovation at charles Charlottesville City Schools, Mr. Jordan, the principal of Buford, soon to be Charlottesville Middle School, and Mr. Paquette, I-STEM teacher at Buford. So what is our vision for the lab school?

[00:08:59] We sort of built our plan on these three guiding principles. We want to develop a community practice, we want to engage all students, and that is pretty important in our plan because it's not a separate entity, it's really engaging all students at Charlottesville Middle School, and we want to make meaningful community connections and this is all built on the foundation of computer science education along with community-based partners to provide the catalyst to engage students in personally meaningful learning experiences that deepen their content area understanding. The mission of the UVA Innovation Hub is to engage all students

[00:09:38] in personally meaningful computational rich and interdisciplinary learning experiences and our vision is that the UVA Innovation Hub provides educational opportunities that inspire curiosity, fuel innovation, and empower all students to solve problems and pursue lifelong learning.

[00:09:56] So as I stated, our lab school is embedded within Charlottesville Middle School, and the UVA Innovation Hub will be the conduit for connecting resources from UVA with Charlottesville Middle School. So the blue circle is sort of all the things that UVA is going to be bringing into the school through the innovation hub. Initially, the lab school will work with the science teachers. All students will have

scheduled time in the UVA innovation hub to work on projects that integrate science and computer science content through community-based problem solving. The science teachers will be part of the innovation academy fellowship, which provides

[00:10:36] substantial financial support similar to an endowed share model. And this year-long cohort-based support program will include summer curriculum design academy, personalized coaching and mentoring through the school year, and valuable externship opportunities. And if we keep going, you'll see that we hope that this model gets replicated in other subject areas so that by year three, we envision teachers in other subject areas will be able to join the Innovation Academy Fellowship. And we also envision that those teachers who've already been through the academy

[00:11:13] will then be potential partners for interdisciplinary projects across the school and advocates for the project-based learning experiences within Charlottesville Middle School. So how will our lab school operate? Year one will start with all seventh grade students having weekly time scheduled in the UVA Innovation Hub to work on at least two integrated projects in science or whatever subject area the Innovation Hub is focused on. Year two will add support for

[00:11:48] 8th grade students to work on capstone projects in the Innovation Hub. In year three, we will add support for all 6th grade students. So that is actually when 6th grade students get added to Charlottesville Middle School. And they'll have time to start building their skills and project experience so they can have a more seamless pathway to these other experiences in 7th and 8th grade. And UVA will be responsible for curriculum support and delivery, professional development research and evaluation mentoring and community connections while ccs charles facility schools will be responsible for student family and teacher engagement standard integration

[00:12:27] logistics and the facilities and thanks to the lab school planning grant we've been able to actually try out a variety of initiatives that will become the building blocks for the uva innovation hub so for the guiding principle of develop a community of practice we started this past summer a curriculum design accelerator with pre and in-service teachers and then two of those teacher pre-service teacher participants were actually placed at Buford for their internship and this is a model that we want to continue placing pre-service teachers at Buford or

[00:13:02] Charlottesville Middle School for their experiences and then we continued to support in-service teachers during the school year and most recently this past January we modeled project-based learning projects in seventh and eighth grade science classrooms and so we'll continue to iterate on this model for the innovation academy fellowship experience through research and evaluation for the guiding principle of engaging all students we created a cs pathway for the summer star hill pathways program as a way to try out project ideas and to link the experience to the curriculum

[00:13:38] design accelerator so that teachers could see this project-based learning and experience in action in january as i said we modeled some pbl the integrated computer science concept with science sols with a biobats project animal adaptations in the seventh grade life science classrooms and create a sound machine in the eighth grade physical science classrooms and these are the type of projects that we envision that the sixth and seventh grade students will be engaged in in the innovation hub as they gain the skills they need to tackle their capstone

[00:14:12] project in eighth grade and the hallmarks of these pbl projects are to give students choices within well-documented design constraints and to give students a variety of ways to express their

creativity and informal polling that we've done now with the students based on these experiences show that they're having an impact a positive impact on their experiences and then for make meaningful community connections we use the summer cs pathway and the project-based learning opportunities we just had this past January as a way to connect with community organizations,

[00:14:51] including Willowtree, Bird Brain Technologies, Computers for Kids, C4K, Boys and Girls Clubs of Central Virginia, UVA School of Data Science, UVA Biomedical Engineering, Steam Kits, Barron Associates, and Tech Girls. So all of these organizations participated in some way, whether they provided mentors or materials, both in the pathway that we ran during the summer with students as well as with the project-based learning that we just completed. And in January, we also launched our first Charlottesville Random Hacks of Kindness, which we envision

[00:15:26] will be a lab school outreach event designed to model engaging students in rural world problem solving with mentors from industry. So we had 40 students, 10 community mentors came in and delivered workshops. And then we had a nonprofit organization, Charlottesville Community Bikes, offer real-world problem statements for the students to solve in the afternoon. And now we've made these connections with the mentors, with the organizations, and we have a real-world problem statement that we can now bring into the school, lab school, during the year into the

[00:16:02] curriculum. So our governing board will consist of UVA School of Education and Human Development and equity center representatives, as well as Charlottesville City School representatives.

[00:16:18] It will also include a community partner representative, and we will build a family and student advisory council, and they will also have a representative. And we've already started outlining the distribution of our responsibilities that we'll eventually formalize into MLU to lay out the terms and conditions of this partnership. And as you can see, the Innovation Hub itself will be run by a director. There'll be a research scientist who will be doing all the research associated with what's going on in the lab school. Year one, we'll have a lab manager working with

[00:16:53] seventh grade. Year two, we'll add an innovation specialist to work with eighth grade. And then year three, we'll add a second innovation specialist for sixth grade. So we have basically a lab manager type person working with all the different grades. So the budget includes capital expenditures which is an improvement project to renovate and update four science classrooms to host the uva innovation hub and the personnel budget as i said includes a director a research

[00:17:29] scientist a lab manager and two innovation specialists the budget also includes innovation academy fellowship incentives for educators professional learning experiences and materials to support student project creation which as we just had this experience in seventh and eighth grade 600 students. It requires a lot of materials for every student to be able to do these kind of projects. Year one will serve seven, will serve 300 seventh grade students. Year two, 600 seventh and eighth grade students. And by year three, we'll serve all of the sixth, seventh and eighth grade,

[00:18:06] which will be around 900 students at Charlottesville Middle School. And now I'm going to hand it back to Dean Rowley to talk a little bit about sustainability. Thank you, Dr. Wilkins. So obviously we want to be able to maintain this incredible work long term and so we do have a three-pronged approach. One is really continuing to engage with our community partners with some of our corporate partners who we believe who will be excited about the benefits that they'll reap with our amazing students on the other side. The second is working with

[00:18:44] our foundation which is our fundraising arm really thinking about this as a core piece of our philanthropic efforts my philanthropic efforts as a as a dean again i know that um that folks will be really excited about the model and eager to support and of course because this is in part a research project or a set of research projects we will be um really going after funding from the federal government from the institute of education sciences and the national

[00:19:15] science foundation and other foundations to continue to fuel the partnership all right well thank you dr gurley dr roley and dr wilkins for that excellent update on your application and for briefing us on the various components i want to be sure to first recognize that committee member mr bailey has joined us he was able to hear your entire presentation he joined just as you were starting so i just want to make sure that you know that he is online with us and that he is part of

[00:19:52] the conversation um before we go into questions i did want to afford uh dr wilkins you did such an amazing job of introducing the entire team that you have on with us virtually if we were in our physical presence space i would give each of your uh supporters and team members an opportunity to address the committee so before we go into questions if any of your other team members would be so inclined i would absolutely welcome them to introduce themselves the role that they play in terms of the lab school application and the lab school and just talk a little bit about

[00:20:31] their own views on it we certainly we've afforded all the other applicants to do that and since you've all taken the time to be here we want to make sure that you have the same opportunity as well it's a little sometimes easier in person because he kind of pushed to the front of the line when it's you know when it's online it's like ah who's going to be the first brave soul but i think doctor i think mr jordan i heard you chiming in so props to you for being the

[00:21:05] first one to start the process sir hi good morning everyone thank you so much uh for having us this morning my name is rodney jordan i am the principal at buford middle school soon to be charlottesville middle school this is my third year and i will say that this has been an exciting process for us working and partnering with uva and trying to establish the lab school here we just had a great time they came over and worked with our students and doing some some projects in

[00:21:39] our science classes and our students were very engaged and enjoy learning new things. So I'm excited about this process. Thank you. Thank you, Principal Jordan. Hi, I'm Dr. Coffey. I'm the coordinator of science innovation for Charlottesville City Schools. I fully support this model. I've been intimately involved with the whole process and just crafting a vision of transitioning from the very traditional model of teaching to something outside of the box. Like we know the traditional model isn't working so let's take this opportunity this lab school and really check

[00:22:19] out some things and experiment with our students and see what truly does work and have them be the guiding light for us and not us let the students kind of lead this model for us so i'm super excited and very enthusiastic about this whole process and hope to see it come to fruition thank - Thank you, Dr. Coffey.

[00:22:42] - Hi, everybody. Thanks for having us this morning. I'm Kevin Paquette. I'm instructional coach here at Buford, working closely with math and science teachers and also been I-STEM teacher here at Buford for the last several years.

[00:22:59] And I'm just excited to have an opportunity to work with the folks at UVA to bring this like approach to science teaching and then teaching middle school generally that we know will engage our students, getting relevant real world type problems in front of our students is a sure way to hook them in and engage them at an age when they're trying to figure out their place in the world and trying to figure out what is meaningful to them.

[00:23:30] I think this is a great way to try to capitalize on that natural inclination of our young adolescents. So I'm very excited and excited about what we've already done this year. Thank you, Mr. Parkett, for being here and for contributing that.

[00:23:48] Yeah, thank you. Just to echo the sentiment, so I'm Ben Allen. I'm the executive director at the UVA Equity Center. And the thing that I would say contribute to this and also just incredibly excited about is the deep partnerships and the authentic partnerships that have occurred through this across the university and the community.

[00:24:06] The Charlottesville-Armoral area is very rich in resources in terms of who serves youth. And there's not a lot of opportunities to connect this in an efficient way to truly form what what we describe as a village around our kids and being able to support them holistically while developing their passions and propelling them to you know careers and advanced education around the computer science pathway so a lot of the scholars that you saw the pictures were from our star hill pathways program which runs over the summer and throughout the school year and again it's just really powerful to see the kids finding connections between what they do out of school and

[00:24:43] in school so that it's not a separate piece, but really excited to be a part of this team. And thank you for inviting us this morning. Thank you, Mr. Allen. Hi, I'm Jenny Chu. I'm an associate professor at the University of Virginia in curriculum and instruction focusing on STEM education. And I have been very excited to be involved in this project from the planning grant throughout these activities. And I'm just very, i'm very much looking forward to putting together what we know are effective practices from the

[00:25:17] research into an actual school and being able to document and try out this model and then be able to disseminate it um outwards to various types of audiences so thank you for this opportunity and i just want to echo what everybody has been saying about it's been lovely to be able to form and to form new partnerships but also build on the existing collaborations that we have in our area so thank you thank you mr chiu and i just also add that dr katina odi who's the chief academic officer from charlottesville city schools couldn't be here but she's a really a core member of our

[00:25:53] team thank you all right at this time uh the normal procedure is we go to our committee members see what questions they may have on your application or the presentation that you've made today Dr. Rowley, I would encourage any member of your team that you feel that is appropriate to answer that question. You yourself can answer it or Dr. Wilkins or Dr. Gurley, but I'll defer to you on who would be the appropriate person to answer. So let's first go to Mr. Hansen.

[00:26:25] Thank you, Madam Chair. Just thank you for this application and just all the work that's gone into it just really appreciate the the vision and the really the hopeful outcomes of this um also just um my heart is near and dear to uva i was on the school of education board for about 10 years with the dean brenneman and then dean pianta and so just really um appreciate the uh the great work in the charlottesville community i'm also a proud

[00:27:03] parent of a daughter who graduated there about 10 years ago too in the same school so um i just had two questions and um one is um just a little bit more of the physicality of the 300 and then 600 900 students so are they going to be on campus dr jordan in your school or what's the relationship with the university going to be um of and then i just have one other question too about some

[00:27:31] continuity but um yeah so all uh when we um when our new school is finished in 2026 we will be adding sixth grade to our school and so that's that's when we're expecting roughly 900 students uh to be in our building and so just to clarify the the lab school part of it the innovation hub part of it we're going to start in science classrooms so that's why there's funds to

[00:28:10] renovate those they're not part of the upgrade that's currently happening to charlotsville middle school and that that's so so the students are going to have scheduled time and innovation have their and then they have their regular scheduled classes um the rest of the time and so just on the budget overview too at the capital expenditures for year one and two of the seven eight hundred thousand is that for the supplies mostly for the science program or is it for across

[00:28:40] the board dr coffee can you take that one so coming in to salt still about a year ago the science wing was renovated about 10 years ago and in those 10 years we found that they're not very conducive for learning they're very large spaces so looking at spending 1.5 million to upgrade the acoustics in the room just the entire footprint of the room isn't again conducive for innovation it's very difficult to hear teachers at the front of the room it's very difficult to see when they're presenting for collaboration when you want students to work

[00:29:20] in teams so the 1.5 first is going to be addressing those issues with technology and space and then the next will be providing access to furniture that allows students to work together and collaborate in teams but it would be in a phased approach so the first year will be looking at the footprint and addressing those issues and then the second year will be bringing in the furniture and that's for four classrooms thank you and just one more question too on just maybe also

[00:29:54] help me um uh fully understand the connectivity through high school and on their uh pathway to to college and just maybe the bridge there when they finish up the sixth seventh and eighth grade experience? Just what the connection is in high school for them. Dr. Gurley, do you want to take the connection to high school question? So, I believe we have various very robust programming

[00:30:31] at our high school. And I know Dr. Coffey can speak a little bit more intimately about what those pathways look like. But what we learned through this process is that our greatest gap was how we get our students hooked. It was at the middle school level. We did not, we were not historically, we've not been affording our students the opportunities to explore and imagine what a world could be like if I were working in the computer science or if I were doing

[00:31:08] something that was connected to a science um and so um and with regards to your question we believe that um what we are building here um the lab school model will connect that seamlessly with our um robotics program our engineering program all those programs that we already have at our high school that there will be a seamless transition um and and actually what we will see is that it will diversify those programs um at the high school level as well because we will get students will

[00:31:44] have a we'll be able to explore that um those fields sooner at the middle school level thank you thank you mr hansen uh doc dr moran oh dr moran we can't hear you quite yet there we go it's always a

matter of finding the unmute button here but um i was going to say that that it's great to be in the room with a lot of people that have i've known for a lot of years and really know

[00:32:23] their commitment to um the kind of work that it takes to move our kids into being ready to live work and thrive in this century and you check a lot of boxes in the proposal on that whether it's deeper learning whether it's active engagement of kids whether it's equity so that this is not a program for some kids but it's one that will really touch the lives of all kids so I love that about the proposal one area that I'm really interested in though is that oftentimes the

[00:32:57] experiences of pre-service teachers our education school students tends to follow the same path over and over again. There's not much that's changed about the experience of placing teacher candidates who are in learning still, and will be hopefully for the rest of their lives, in programs in public schools. And I'm wondering what you're thinking that would potentially both

[00:33:29] intensify and increase impact on the students enrolled in the School of Education, how that experience might be different as a result of working on this particular proposal, rather than just being a, okay, let's take a teacher and pair them up with an educator in a school that's already an experienced teacher. I see, Jenny, you're kind of nodding your head.

[00:33:59] Dean Rowley, I didn't know if you wanted to say anything beforehand. Well, this, as you know, Dr. Moran, it's near and dear to my heart as I was just teaching the future science teachers and trying to place them in our new pilot system as well as within the traditional system that we have.

[00:34:21] And so what really excites me is that as Dr. Wilkins presented, we had pre-service teachers coming into the um star hills pathway over the summer to see to engage in these computational activities alongside the students the middle school youth to see what kinds of assets and resources and how they can just pick this stuff up no problem and get going and go and then as well to be part of the curriculum design accelerator where then they're deconstructing these experiences and thinking about how they're going to translate that into their classrooms

[00:34:57] as well as thinking uh with this innovation hub um what i'll give you a very specific example um so um trying to place science teachers in uh classrooms where they're doing um inquiry problem-based project base is very uh can be very challenging but um having the innovation hub where pre-service teachers are coming in and seeing uh these this kind of project-based community-based deep approach with students, I think will be a different model to engage pre-service teachers,

[00:35:34] teacher candidates in. And so that's one of the very exciting pieces for me, is to be able to try this out and to be able to communicate that with the field. Dr. Moran, we can't hear you muting myself, which is a good thing. Otherwise, I talk too much. But

[00:35:56] The other piece that I'm really interested in is the sustainability is always one of the questions that we ask. And so my next part is, how does the city schools and the university really find the long-term sustainable commitment?

[00:36:16] Too many times I've seen projects get started, and they're great projects, and they die, and they start, and they disappear. How will this project be supported, both in terms of the financial support, but also the cultural and logistical support and academic support to keep this moving forward past the life of the grant?

[00:36:41] Thank you. It's good to see you. And so I'll start, but then maybe Dr. Gurley can follow up a bit. So to me, this is really the future of the way that we're teaching our pre-service teachers, as Dr. Chu pointed out. And so this is sort of folded into our program there, but it's also part of our ongoing mission. So we're in the middle of our strategic planning

[00:37:15] period right now, and really focused on these kinds of partnerships. I also think because of the incredible value of having workforce-ready students come out of our public schools, I think that there will be a lot of corporate interest. And so, you know, we're folding it into our broader plan for how we prepare our own teachers and how we think about UBA-EHD partnerships more generally.

[00:37:43] And so, you know, I think the big thing is how we maintain this amazing team of folks and keep everyone at the table and then just, you know, continue to have it as a major priority for the school.

[00:38:00] But I think for School of Education and Human Development, I should say, Dr. Gurley, did you want to add to that? With regards to the sustainability component, we too just completed our strategic plan, and the Innovation Hub aligns directly to our work. One of our core values in our new strategic plan is the joy of learning, and we most certainly feel that this will foster the joy of learning.

[00:38:32] We are in the middle of our budget process, and we sent a survey out to our stakeholders, And with regards to feedback, they said that they wanted the strategic plan to be the guide and document as it relates to generating the budget.

[00:38:49] And so as we think about sustainability, you know, we fund those things that we prioritize. And I believe that this will be one of the things that we will prioritize for a very long time because it will yield an academic return on investment.

[00:39:09] And I think that concludes, so thank you for those answers. That is very illuminative. Thank you. Thank you, Dr. Moran, and thank you to the UVA team for that additional information.

[00:39:29] Mr. Bailey, at this time, are there any queries you'd like to present to the UVA team? No, just, I mean, really impressive application. Thank you for all the time and effort you took to develop it and also to help connect it to standards of learning.

[00:39:45] The assessment is just very impressive. The one theme that I noticed, at least for me, that really jumped out was the idea of mentoring. You were just talking about this with pre-service teachers, getting a chance to kind of see, learn the practice from both skilled professionals as well as some of your partners.

[00:40:02] And you also talked a little bit about C4K in your proposal. And I know they play a pretty significant role with mentoring. I know also just from past, you know, the difference between a really good project-based learning activity and one that's just mediocre is the role of mentors.

[00:40:24] And so could you maybe just talk a little bit more about C4K and just also the way you see them playing in to the project-based work that the students would be doing? Dr. Wilkins, do you want to take that one?

[00:40:40] Sure. Yeah, I've been involved with C4K for a very, very long time. And so when we started this process, they were like, yes, we're going to collaborate and partner with them. So I think they have an excellent model for mentoring.

[00:40:56] They also have excellent models for project-based learning, which is why over the summer we brought both the students from the CS Pathway as well as the pre-service and in-service teachers to that space so they could see what that looks like.

[00:41:12] And I envision in the future, oh, we also, with the hackathon, I don't think they were able to participate this time, but that is, you know, a thing that we want to build in with them as well. But going forward, I think that they are an organization that we can use as part of professional learning for teachers to, you know, kind of see during the school year times where we want to see some project-based learning happening and we can use, do, you know, a field trip to there and really get a sense for how they do things.

[00:41:55] Dr. Rapp, Mr. Bailey, go ahead. That's a wonderful question, Mr. Bailey. And I think not only C4K, but the students are getting experiences with multiple community partners that work in this computer science space. There's also workforce development. You saw in the pictures that they went to Willow Tree, which is one of the largest tech companies here. And often students don't have that time to do so. And so what we're looking at is the infrastructure that facilitates these relationships and also connecting them to meaningful mentorship layers, not only for community nonprofits that are youth serving, but also the layer that is university students, both graduate and undergraduate students,

[00:42:35] from our perspective as the ones who help coordinate a lot of the summer work, we're very intentional about the counselors we hire so that the counselors we are hiring are getting their bachelor's in computer science or related field so that they're able to not only talk to the students just from like, you know, peer, a little bit older peer network, but also like, hey, this is what it looks like in college. Same thing with graduate students. And then also the UVA faculty and staff that are involved. So again, we're just trying to connect many layers of mentorship for the students so that at some point there's many folks that are care and have

[00:43:08] this circle of care around our students. Excellent. Thank you very much. Hearing no further comments from the other committee members, first I want to thank again to UVA for the application. I think that we both appreciate the quality and the depth and the intentionality of the vision you've presented. Just as was noted by Mr. Allen, what comes through in your application

[00:43:45] is a very, it's an evidence-based approach that you're rather than organically doing what we know works well for young people, you're very intentionally building into the day. And that comes through in the application, kind of jumps off the page. So I want to thank you. And just looking at my screen, seeing the very many partners that are involved in the application is incredible, that you're really developing and building a permanent ecosystem around these students for their success that leverages the assets throughout the Charlottesville community.

[00:44:20] I think you've already answered my question, which is I usually ask a little bit about, tell us a bit about a day in the life of the students, or tell us a bit about the day in the life of a student who's in the pre-service. If there's anything that you'd like to further share in terms of a day of the life of a student, I would be happy to entertain that. But I do feel that you've given us a really robust picture of what that would look like for all students.

[00:44:45] But let me just pause there and see if there's any additional thoughts that come to mind that you want to share about your program. Okay. All right. Excellent. At this time, what I'd like to do is turn our attention to Dr. Andy Armstrong, who is going to give us an update on the subject matter review that was done of your application by the VDOE. Thank you, Madam Chair and committee members i would like

to do just that and provide a brief overview on behalf of the agency on the university of virginia's innovation hub at charlottesville middle school's lab school application as it relates to their completeness and compliance as you have heard the innovation

[00:45:25] hub would provide a stem and computer science infused project-based learning experience to all charlottesville city public schools middle school students within three years of opening uva school of education human development the uva equity center and charlottesville city schools have presented an ambitious and exciting plan and their application is the first to propose to serve middle school students from among our college partnership lab school applicants and as a six year middle school principal as well i am especially excited about that our review of the uva application has included multiple rounds of subject matter expert feedback and several calls

[00:45:59] since the submission of the application in november of 2023 uva has been responsive and inquisitive and that's a good thing as they have thoughtfully adjusted their plan to meet the compliance requirements of virginia lab schools and answered questions of our subject matter expert team as you will see in the attached completeness and compliance report for the purposes of first standing committee review today the uva innovation hub is ready to implement in the elements of executive summary mission and vision governance placement plan other assurances and financial and operations under educational program and uva is aware of this we would like to clarify if there

[00:46:36] are any alternative assessments other than SOLs be used to measure progress. And under management structure, we have some minor questions about time periods associated with staffing, evaluation of staff, HR policies, and partnerships. And I've heard some of the answers actually today in the presentation, and we will work with UVA to make those revisions in the weeks to come pending the next move from the committee today. Thank you, Dr. Armstrong, and please thank again all the subject matter experts that have been involved at VDOE that took the time to review the application and work collaboratively with the applicant. Are there any questions from the committee members on

[00:47:14] VDOE's review of the application? Okay. I don't have any questions and just appreciate that Dr. Armstrong's summary is always concise but very clear about where the department sees this grant falling on a continuum of meeting the accountability and compliance regs and law as well as giving us insight into how the department sees this as adding value to the lab school initiative.

[00:47:47] I did want to just note for the record the one thing I meant to say when I was asking questions is that what has been unique about this particular proposal to me today is the fact that we have a superintendent a part of the presentation we have this dean of the education school as a part of the presentation all the way down to the person who will help make this uva innovation lab work so having all of the players actually be a part of the presentation i think adds great value to it in terms of my perspective thank you dr moran all right hearing no further questions for dr

[00:48:24] armstrong at this time is there a motion to approve the university of virginia and charleston application for a lab school for first review and to post the application for a 10-day public comment period. I move the motion. A motion from Mr. Hansen, is there a second? Second. Second from Dr. Moran. All those in favor of the motion, please signify by saying aye. Aye. Mr. Bailey votes aye, Dr. Moran votes aye, Mr. Hansen votes aye, and the chair votes aye. The motion is approved.

[00:48:58] congratulations on behalf of the committee i now direct the staff to post the university of virginia's application for a 10-day public comment period in accordance with the standing committee's

procedures then compile any comments received for review by the standing committee when the application returns for second review at our march meeting in person back in richmond thank you very much for appearing before the committee today i'm going to just take a brief pause there for uva's team to first congratulate you on getting to this juncture and to second say you don't have to stay for the rest of our committee meeting you're welcome to stay but it sounds like

[00:49:36] from your application you have quite a few things that you need to work on so please take this opportunity to take leave from our meeting and thank you again and we'll see you back in march thank you so much thank you thanks everybody all right now we'll move to item b on our agenda which is the College Partnership Lab School Application Pipeline and Expenditure Upright from Dr. Armstrong. Thank you, Madam Chair. I'm going to attempt to share my screen briefly for

[00:50:08] this operative word being attempt. Let's see here. Okay, and we're going to switch to another tab. All right, is everyone seeing our table? Great. We had a big day on Friday, Madam Chair, members of the committee. We had six applications that were submitted on Friday, and as you all may remember i did set a deadline at february 2nd for application submission so this this pipeline

[00:50:43] is not reflecting all the most recent submissions and it will reflect that in march and i will actually get it to to the folks here in the agency as well because i know they'll be interested where we are right now in the process just a few highlights we received our six applications on friday in addition to five that are currently in review as we meet here today and that includes Zimmer and Henry, Piedmont, Virginia Community College, Central Virginia Community College, Mountain Gateway, and Richard Bland College. And those have all, five of those have been through one round of subject matter review. We're awaiting responses from them or revisions so that we can

[00:51:23] consider them for next steps in the process. The six we received on Friday included three from ODU, from Old Dominion University, one with Suffolk, one with Chesapeake, one with Newport News, one from Ferrum, one from Roanoke, and then we received one that had not applied for a planning grant, and that was the Virginia Western Governor's School in a partnership with Roanoke County Public Schools. So all that to say, first, that now that our planning grants are closed, we will be having a tremendous amount of work to do in the months ahead as an agency in reviewing

[00:52:00] these applications. But I also want to note that I'm optimistic that we are definitely going to spend the monies that have been awarded in this grant fund. And if nothing else, we are probably going to need to scrutinize budget ask even more carefully moving forward to ensure that we maximize every dollar that is in our grant fund. We had a total as of now of 30 interested higher ed institutions or 30 applicants. Some of those came from the same higher ed institution and we had 21 planning grants that were approved. So this has been a tremendous amount of work and I want to

[00:52:38] thank the committee because without your support in doing this, I don't think anyone imagined, I know myself included, when I took this job in August that we would sit here today in February deliberating well over 20 lab school applications. And with that being said, I know there was a question that we had the last meeting about how we could potentially move some of these funds categorically. I did speak with the folks in finance here in the agency, and we will have about a million dollars left in the planning grant fund, which while that cannot be used for any other

[00:53:15] uses such as learning network establishments, and we've discussed that a little bit, it can be moved into the operational funds, as well as if we have funding left over in the startup fund, we can also

move that into the operational funding pool so we're going to need to really sharpen our pencils here in the agency in the in the weeks ahead as we look at applications to make sure that that we are working within the the the limits we have here with the grant fund but i think it's also a testament to the work that we've done to see that much interest that we've gotten from higher institutions um really speaks to the work that of the committee and of the agency and and i'm

[00:53:53] excited to engage in this work in the next few months but i'm happy to take any questions right now about our pipeline or any specific applicants as well dr armstrom thank you for this again and just congrats for getting five more and and um and also just thank you for the clarification and open the question at the last meeting on the usage of the any unspent funds in the first two categories and just i know we've talked about this previously too but could you maybe just refresh me beyond Virginia Union and which of these are HBCUs and maybe just any insights you

[00:54:32] might be able to provide to us there. And it looks like Virginia State did not submit an application. Is that right? That's correct. I do have a call today with Virginia Union. Their representative reached out to me last week and we're going to discuss their application today. And Norfolk State, I have not received feedback from since I reached out to them and talked to them before the winter break, and I did send another communication to all lab school applicants last week, actually. I have not heard anything back from Norfolk State at this point, and yes, Virginia State eventually did not submit a lab school planning grant application. Hampton has

[00:55:11] also expressed some interest, but has yet to apply. Got it. Thank you, sir. You're welcome. Mr. Hanson, one of the things that we have, you'll note that Hampton University is included on this document, even though they have not submitted. One of the things that Dr. Armstrong and the team we've decided to do with the chart is to be transparent also about inquiries and potential interest. So, you know, there might be an institution that inquired, explored, but maybe didn't move forward. But we do want it. We did want the committee members to be aware of that

[00:55:50] ongoing work and engagement with BDOE. And really, I want to give a compliment to Dr. Armstrong. he has really gone above and beyond to reach out to personally call institutions. He has sent multiple emails to institutions, set up opportunities for them to get personalized technical assistance and support any questions answered. And I think that that type of that level of service is exactly what we want our leaders to offer as a partner to higher ed

[00:56:25] applicants and to K-12 schools, for that matter, in the state, that they view individuals at VDOE not merely as a compliance, you know, like good old-fashioned bureaucrat, but we really want them to see individuals like Dr. Armstrong and the team that we know we have at VDOE as partners in the work and accessible. And so I want to thank Dr. Armstrong for really modeling that in his engagement with the higher ed institutions throughout this process. Thank you, Madam Chair. Dr. Armstrong and I even had an opportunity to do an onsite technical assistance visit two weeks ago,

[00:57:03] which is wonderful. So the roadshow continues. So if you are one of these interested applicants and you've submitted your application and you would like an onsite TA, we're happy to come to you too. Madam Chair, I apologize. I did want to just reiterate that in our communication, we did offer the onsite visits as calendars permit. We have office hours every Monday that that people can sign up for and i have emails and calls pretty much daily with our applicants as we

[00:57:37] just coach them through this process thank you andy for your great work and the team's great work and all this appreciate it i apologize if i can't see some of the other committee members right now if you have a question there we go now i have my full screen again um any other questions uh for dr armstrong otherwise we'll move to item c so andy for the five that have moved something forward to you when do you think that we might anticipate the potential to see any of those

[00:58:19] to my right here in my office have a whiteboard and that whiteboard is completely encompassed by this diagram of march april may and june and i anticipate that we will have hopefully three additional applications for the standing committee's review in march we also still have mountain gateway awaiting their second standing committee review as well and then in april um anticipating four and potentially another four in may so again a lot of this is going to depend on again how our review goes and responsiveness on behalf of the applicants but we've

[00:58:57] mapped it out and i think we can expect to see an average of hopefully three or four per month moving forward thank you oh okay let's move to item c which is the virginia lab schools and Innovation Network. Dr. Armstrong, please continue. Yes, ma'am. I'm going to share it one more time.

[00:59:20] Okay. As I fumble through here. All right. Everyone's seeing a PowerPoint presentation.

[00:59:52] Great. I see some heads shaking. Excellent. Thank you, Madam Chair and committee members. While we have been making a tremendous effort to process applications, to provide compliance, technical assistance applicants, to set agendas for our committees and our state boards, we cannot ignore the fact that here in only a few months, we will see the first of our approved lab schools operational open for business. As a matter of fact, VCU Code RVA is currently operational and

[01:00:27] open for business. And in that spirit, we want to make sure that we are providing attention to the need to establish networks of innovation, a learning network, not just for our lab schools, but really to incorporate our lab schools into the broader work of innovation here in the Commonwealth, which has been my charge since I took on my position here in the BDOE.

[01:00:50] And I want to talk and, again, take any feedback I can from the committee today about this work moving forward, as it is critical, I feel, for the long-term success of all the work we've been doing to approve lab schools. We talked about sustainability today, and I know that one dimension of that is going to be the finances and the operations, but another as important dimension is how do they support each other?

[01:01:13] What are the resources they need to administer their program and to continue to provide this product for students here in Virginia? The desired outcomes of this learning network will have to start, first of all, with an accurate and robust sharing of data.

[01:01:29] Right now, I will tell you that the Office of Data Research and Technology is developing that very robust tableau that we hope to have available to the public in the months ahead that includes information about all the options and the regional centers and the choices that students really have here in the Commonwealth, and you can manipulate that by division, by type of center. We want to integrate lab schools into that, so our first step is going to be really standing up that visualization for the public to understand where these opportunities

[01:02:05] exist and to make sure that we're incorporating lab schools into that network, and then once you have that, we need to create communication that works among all the players in all of those programs,

including our lab schools. So how do we create very efficient means of communication where ideas can be shared, whether it's among the entire group or between those who have certain similar themes or desired outcomes or workplace partnerships, and then establish those communication methods accordingly. And what this really should do eventually is create this

[01:02:42] advocacy and thought partner network among all of our innovative programs in Virginia, including our lab schools. And we heard from ILS months ago here, and we need to think of how we can integrate them, where places we can find resources at the local, state, national, even the global level to provide our lab schools as they move forward. And this will be a task for sure it will require that manpower will require funds and technology. And I did outline a few of those needs that I think are at the top of the list, which would include the human resources to

[01:03:18] do that. We'll need personnel to maintain and administer this network. We'll need to warehouse and distribute these resources. We'll need to plan events, whether it's in-person or virtual, and make sure we're providing that feedback. As Ms. Wadiska noted, that customer service that we really want to give here from the agency will need to extend to our lab schools here in the years ahead, especially. The technology will need to be adapted to facilitate these networks. And of course, all this will not come at zero cost. We'll need to also explore in the future how we can fund this. I had a conversation with a colleague, and again, on my whiteboard here in

[01:03:55] my office, just as an aside, they really talked about this entire process. We have had to evaluate and administer planning grants. We provided technical assistance to applicants. There is a good amount of administrative work that goes into this approval process. And then we have to administer the grants themselves once our lab schools are up and running. So we're really managing several processes. And then what really brings it full circle will be this learning network that we'll be able to establish among our lab schools within that greater umbrella of of innovative practice here in the state of Virginia. I hope by this March that we will be

[01:04:34] able to debut that research and technology visualization and dashboard with our existing innovative practices here in the state. And then in the summer, really work to survey those who are in that network to get their feedback about really what works in terms of how we communicate and what the goals of this network will be. And hopefully in the fall, we can develop leadership around this Innovation Network, plan for implementation, include some initial communications, possibly a kickoff event, even if it's virtual, and then begin to share resources, and then over time start to refine and implement those plans and adapt as these choice programs grow, as

[01:05:13] our lab schools evolve, and really add to the sustainability of what we've been doing as a committee, but also what our agency has been doing to promote innovation here in the Commonwealth. So knowing that we're going to have many different partners, our lab schools are diverse in their objectives and how they're structured and what their outcomes are for students. We want to make sure that we're gathering meaningful feedback as we move forward with establishing this network. So I'm thinking about surveys, focus group engagement with existing programs, potential future partners, and also creating those really clear paths to share

[01:05:51] this work statewide and nationally as we move forward. So this is an important spoke in the wheel of innovation here in Virginia. And I feel that this is one that while we have been immersed in the

application process right now, providing technical assistance, we need to move forward on while we're doing this in order to make sure we're providing support to our lab schools.

[01:06:16] So I'm going to stop my share, and I'm happy to take any questions. Again, this is very somewhat theoretical at this point. We're trying to really create some concrete timelines and some concrete objectives, but I would love to hear the committee's feedback and take that and move forward.

[01:06:34] Dr. Moran? Unmute. I need my coffee mug that says unmute. I think that, Andy, that you and I have actually touched base about a couple of times that there is a real need to have a sustainable model for both looking at support and sustaining the lab schools as a network, as well as an accountability focus on how do we really

[01:07:07] measure the impact over time. So one of the things that I'm also wondering about is whether you see that network running through the department supervision or whether you see an intermediary potentially being able to work with building out that network and then working with the department? Do you have some sense of what direction you would see that going?

[01:07:38] And Dr. Moran, I think now that we have a dedicated office of innovation here at the agency, I know that we would likely take the lead. However, I do feel that depending on needs and bandwidth of the office, I think it's very reasonable to expect that we would pursue partnerships potentially with third-party organizations that could really help us move that work forward.

[01:08:13] Any other questions or comments for Dr. Armstrong? Okay. I'm sorry, Mr. Hansen.

[01:08:22] Andy, just any, you know, so much of the innovative thoughts going on around the Commonwealth and all these applications and a lot of the uniqueness, even the one we just saw with the middle school is, I know with the network and the, you know, communications effort, but just any notion on just sharing the best practices and also just, you know, the innovative thoughts.

[01:08:55] I know you've got a lot of this listed here on your slides, but just how those could be shared, not just whether it's webinars or even a convening in 25 or 26, but just any thoughts along those lines.

[01:09:17] Mr. Hanson, those are some of the ideas exactly, as a matter of fact, that I've been thinking about in-person virtual convenings, webinars, thinking of ways that we can really make this dynamic. I would say, and I put on my division-level educator hat, that this is a need not just with schools of innovation or lab schools or regional centers, but in a broad sense, there is a lot of room for idea sharing to take place among public educators in Virginia, period. We have the resources,

[01:09:56] technology to do so. And the very ideas you mentioned are some that I've thought about, some efficient, but hopefully manageable ways to do that. And then there may be subgroups even within this network of whether it's by grade level or by region, or as mentioned earlier, by industry-focused outcomes. There's a lot of different ways you can go with it. We just want it to be meaningful. We want it to be something that contributes to the overall

[01:10:26] success of our lab schools. This is something that behind the scenes, Dr. Armstrong and I have talked about rather extensively. I know that Dr. Moran, Mr. Hansen, Mr. Bailey, all of us have talked about privately as well as publicly. There really are a couple branches to this tree that be so incredibly important for the schools you have the element of sustainability from a funding perspective sustainability for the work here in the commonwealth the opportunity to learn which

[01:11:02] uniquely defines lab schools not only for the students but for our community of practice more broadly here in the commonwealth that we can learn from what is going on in the laboratory of these schools and apply it more broadly to the practice dr moran surfaces appropriately so there's also an element of accountability and ensuring that what is offered in all the schools as they are stood up is consistent at a minimum with the requirements in the commonwealth and and what we are learning from that one of the elements that i'm particularly struck by when we have spoken to

[01:11:38] some of our existing our now our newly created almost formed lab schools is the real need to continue to be a partner with them it's not enough to say hey you're approved as a lab school good luck hope it goes well we have to continue to be a partner in their work and so frequently in education unfortunately you know there there's kind of this isolation model of we put a teacher in a classroom go teach figure it out and and i think we're really trying to break that model

[01:12:12] and and model a different behavior and how the lab school community can more broadly help create a ecosystem and a community of innovation across the commonwealth we know that in virginia we have many options for young people that there is a great history of innovation in public schools as well as institutions of higher education and as dr armstrong indicated one of the things that we have not had yet in the commonwealth is an inventory of those assets in that knowledge and

[01:12:48] an ability to apply that knowledge going forward and so i think what you're what doctor what we encourage dr armstrong to to put this up on the docket for for not only the committee members today to surface these private conversations that we all are having private you know behind the scenes and talking about and thinking about and the lab schools themselves they're thinking about they want to work with one another they want to learn from one another um is that through the lab committee we will have the opportunity to also solicit the public's input and what might be an

[01:13:22] effective way to help support the lab schools and the broader ecosystem of innovation within the commonwealth and how can we really all be innovation amplifiers and innovation partners and so this will become a new standing item just like the pipeline agenda item will have the innovation network item and we'll be looking for feedback from the public we'll be looking for feedback from the committee members and partners as to how can we uh continue to improve as a

[01:13:53] commonwealth together so thank you dr armstrong go go ahead apologies madam chair um i i'm hopeful that i could potentially demonstrate this visualization this force in march as i continue to work with dr meyers and his team and i did want to also respond to dr moran's question about accountability um one place where i've received a great deal of support is from our partners at the office of attorney general and i want to thank susan williams for being on the call today but one piece that we have had to really uh work on it has kind of been born out of our contracting

[01:14:31] process is what are these performance expectations going to be and i have now gotten some feedback from the office of accountability as well to make sure that we're meeting the statutory requirements that are that exists for lab schools but also to make sure that we are accounting for the lab school specific outcomes that that each applicant is including in their application so that is part of the contract but we want to also be more explicit about that too as we work with our lab school applications and and andy i think that that that i really appreciate of you working

[01:15:08] across the the departments both internal and external to the doe that have a a sense of responsibility in this because it is a while it's not you know in the big scheme of millions and millions and

millions and millions of dollars that go into education in virginia the amount of money going into the lab schools is not a significant footprint in comparison to the overall funding but it is a sizable amount of money that we are investing in standing up these lab schools

[01:15:43] and as a result of that you know I think that that both from the standpoint of you know taxpayers wanting to know that that they're getting something in return in terms of the cost benefit it's important for us to be able to communicate what is changing as a result of it so what I really think about is that the concept of an external evaluator that might stay with these proposals as they become implemented plans and then over time longitudinally. One of the things I think we want to know is do we get better student teachers becoming more effective first-year

[01:16:23] teachers as a result of a different experience in the lab schools than the traditional student teaching experience do we have impact on kids in the areas of durable skills workforce readiness the kinds of things that that a number of these proposals have laid out so that there maybe is a big picture accountability that's around the lab school initiative and then a more writ small accountability around each lab school's specific goals so that we are able to actually

[01:16:59] get some forecasting data about when we implement a program like this is it possible that it could actually if implemented in more to scale improve the learning environments and the actual outcomes of students across virginia how are these kids doing in comparison to the normative traditions of school i don't know i mean i just think it's it's a big conversation much bigger than just the the lab school committee. But as an educator, it's the kind of thing that I really think we

[01:17:35] should be delivering to our public. So it's just a perspective. Absolutely. Agreed completely. And I'm glad we recorded this because your comments, I think, responded on Dr. Brand. So I'll go back to those. Thank you. Thank you, Dr. Armstrong. And I'm looking forward to this particular item on our agenda. Part of our role is advising the state board and in our duty, advising them on um how to further support innovation how to share and create a community of practice that really does

[01:18:09] as a game changer that's part of part of the scope so so thank you for doing that at this time um i'm just going to check in with dr armstrong to see are there is there any public comment on non-agenda items no no one signed up for any public comment okay thank you dr armstrong um any other comments from members of the committee on items related to our work okay our next meeting will be in person back in richmond we have made it through our maiden voyage of a virtual meeting seems to have

[01:18:43] all gone well we may use this once or one more time this year uh so that to come but back in back in richmond for march and we look forward to seeing you all along with our lab school applicants at that next meeting. At this time, we stand adjourned. Thank you very much.